Specification of Python §2—2025 edition

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The language "Python §x" is a sublanguage of Python 3.13 and defined in the documents titled "Python §x", where x refers to the respective textbook chapter.

1 Changes

Compared to Source §1, Source §2 has the following changes:

- `None`: primitive linked list expression (empty linked list).
- Linked list library: Functions for creating, accessing and processing linked lists.

2 Syntax

A Python program is a *program*, defined using Backus-Naur Form[1] as follows:

[1]We adopt Henry Ledgard's BNF variant that he described in *A human engineered variant of BNF*, ACM SIGPLAN Notices, Volume 15 Issue 10, October 1980, Pages 57-62. In our grammars, we use **`bold`** font for keywords, *italics* for syntactic variables, ϵ for nothing, $x \mid y$ for x or y, $[\ x\ ]$ for an optional x, x... for zero or more repetitions of x, and $(\ x\ )$ for clarifying the structure of BNF expressions.

program	::=	*import-stmt*... *block*	program
statement	::=	*name* **=** *expression*	variable declaration
	|	**def** *name* **(** *names* **) :** *block*	function declaration
	|	**return** *expression*	return statement
	|	*if-statement*	conditional statement
	|	*expression*	expression statement
names	::=	ϵ | *name* (**,** *name*)...	name list
if-statement	::=	**if** *expression***:** *block*	
		(**elif** *expression***:** *block*)...	
		else : *block*	conditional statement
block	::=	*statement*...	block statement
expression	::=	*number*	primitive number expression
	|	**true** | **false**	primitive boolean expression
	|	**None**	primitive linked list expression
	|	*string*	primitive string expression
	|	*name*	name expression
	|	*expression binary-operator expression*	binary operator combination
	|	*unary-operator expression*	unary operator combination
	|	*expression binary-logical expression*	logical composition
	|	*expression* **(** *expressions* **)**	function application
	|	**lambda** (*name* | **(** *names* **)**) **:** *expression*	lambda expression
	|	*expression* **if** *expression* **else** *expression*	conditional expression
	|	**(** *expression* **)**	parenthesised expression
binary-operator	::=	**+** | **-** | ***** | **/** | ****** | **%** |	
		== | **!=** | **>** | **<** | **>=** | **<=**	binary operator
unary-operator	::=	**not** | **-**	unary operator
binary-logical	::=	**and** | **or**	logical composition symbol
expressions	::=	ϵ | *expression* (**,** *expression*)...	argument expressions

Indentation

In Python, indentation is syntactically significant and strictly enforces code block structure. Unlike languages using braces, Python employs whitespace (spaces or tabs) to delimit blocks for control flow (e.g., `if`, `for`, `while`), function definitions, and class declarations. Key rules:

- Consistency: Use 4 spaces per indentation level (PEP 8 recommendation). Mixing tabs and spaces is prohibited.
- Alignment: Statements within the same block must align vertically. Misaligned indentation raises an `IndentationError`.
- Nesting: Each nested block increases indentation by one level. Dedenting resumes the outer block.
- Line Continuation: For multi-line statements, align wrapped lines with the opening delimiter or use an extra level.

Restrictions

- In Python, a logical line is the smallest unit of code that the interpreter can execute, typically corresponding to a complete statement. A physical line, by contrast, is a single line in the source file, usually ending with a newline character. A logical line may span multiple physical lines depending on whether line joining is used.

  By default, each physical line corresponds to a logical line. However, when a statement is too long, Python allows it to be split across multiple physical lines using line continuation. Python provides two ways to join lines: **explicit line joining** and **implicit line joining**.

  Explicit line joining uses a backslash (\) to join the current physical line with the next one, forming a single logical line. The backslash must be the last character on the line—no characters (including whitespace or comments) are allowed after it.

  ```
  total = 1 + 2 + 3 + \
          4 + 5
  ```

  Implicit line joining occurs when expressions are enclosed in parentheses `()`, square brackets `[]`, or braces `{}`. Within these delimiters, line breaks are allowed without using a backslash.

  ```
  total = (
              1 + 2 + 3 +
              4 + 5
           )
  ```

  Therefore, when breaking a statement across lines, you must either use a backslash for explicit continuation or wrap the expression in parentheses, brackets, or braces for implicit continuation. Unlike JavaScript, which uses automatic semicolon insertion, Python requires each line to be syntactically complete—it does not infer the end of a statement implicitly.

  For details on logical lines, see the official Python documentation: Python Lexical Analysis – Logical Lines.

- Return statements are only allowed in bodies of functions. Each return statement must appear on a single logical line.
- Lambda expressions are limited to a single logical line.
- Re-declaration variables or functions is not allowed. Once a variable or function is defined, it cannot be redefined with the same name in the same scope [2].

[2] Scope refers to the region of a program in which a particular name (such as a variable, function, or class) is defined and can be accessed. In other words, it determines the part of the program where you can use that name without causing a name error. Scope is determined by the program's structure (usually its lexical or textual layout) and governs the visibility and lifetime of variables and other identifiers.

In Python, the *scope* of a declaration is determined lexically: a variable declared inside a function is local to that function; if it is declared outside any function, it is global (i.e., module-level). Moreover, if a variable is declared in an enclosing function, it is available to inner functions (the enclosing scope), and if not found in these scopes, Python looks into the built-in scope.

Names

Names[3] start with _, or a letter[4] and contain only _, letters or digits[5]. Reserved words[6] are not allowed as names.
Valid names are `x`, `_45`, and π, but always keep in mind that programming is communicating and that the familiarity of the audience with the characters used in names is an important aspect of program readability.

Numbers

Python supports three numeric types: integers (`int`), floats (`float`), and complex numbers (`complex`).

Integers (`int`)

Integers can be represented in decimal notation, optionally prefixed with a sign (+ or −). Additional base notations are supported, such as binary (`0b1010` or `0B1010`), octal (`0o777` or `0O777`), and hexadecimal (`0x1A3F` or `0X1A3F`). Underscores (_) may be used for readability (e.g., `1_000_000`). Examples include `42`, `-0b1101`, and `0x_FF_00`.

Floats (`float`)

Floats use decimal notation with an optional decimal dot. Scientific notation (multiplying the number by 10^x) is indicated with the letter `e` or `E`, followed by the exponent `x`. Special values inf (infinity), -inf, and nan (not a number) are allowed. Examples include `3.14`, `-0.001e+05`, and `6.022E23`.

Complex Numbers (`complex`)

Complex numbers are written as `<real>±<imag>j`, where `j` (or `J`) denotes the imaginary unit. Both the real and imaginary parts are stored as floats. The imaginary part is mandatory (e.g., `5j`, `0j`, and `0 + 3j` is valid, `5` alone is real).
Examples include `2+3j`, `-4.5J`, `0j`, and `1e3-6.2E2J`.

Strings

Strings are of the form `"`*double-quote-characters*`"`, where *double-quote-characters* is a possibly empty sequence of characters without the character `"` and without the newline character, of the form `'`*single-quote-characters*`'`, where *single-quote-characters* is a possibly empty sequence of characters without the character `'` and without the newline character, and of the form `'''`*triple-single-quote-c*
or `"""`*triple-double-quote-characters*`"""` where *backquote-characters* is a possibly empty sequence of characters and can span multiple lines and may contain both single and double quotes without escaping.
The following characters can be represented in strings[7] as given:

- `\<newline>`: Backslash followed by a newline is ignored.
- `\\`: Represents a backslash (i.e., \).
- `\'`: Represents a single quote ('').
- `\"`: Represents a double quote ("").
- `\a`: Represents the ASCII Bell (BEL) character.

[3] In Python 3.13 Documentation, these names are called *identifiers*.
[4] By *letter* we mean Unicode letters (L) or letter numbers (Nl).
[5] By *digit* we mean characters in the Unicode categories Nd (including the decimal digits 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9), Mn, Mc and Pc.
[6] By *reserved word* we mean any of: **`False`**, **`await`**, **`else`**, **`import`**, **`pass`**, **`None`**, **`break`**, **`except`**, **`in`**, **`raise`**, **`True`**, **`class`**, **`finally`**, **`is`**, **`return`**, **`and`**, **`continue`**, **`for`**, **`lambda`**, **`try`**, **`as`**, **`def`**, **`from`**, **`nonlocal`**, **`while`**, **`assert`**, **`del`**, **`global`**, **`not`**, **`with`**, **`async`**, **`elif`**, **`if`**, **`or`**, **`yield`**. These are all reserved words, or keywords of the language that cannot be used as ordinary identifiers.
[7] In Python 3.13 Documentation, unless an 'r' or 'R' prefix is present, escape sequences in string and bytes literals are interpreted according to rules similar to those used by Standard C. *identifiers*.

- `\b`: Represents the ASCII Backspace (BS) character.
- `\f`: Represents the ASCII Formfeed (FF) character.
- `\n`: Represents the ASCII Linefeed (LF) character.
- `\r`: Represents the ASCII Carriage Return (CR) character.
- `\t`: Represents the ASCII Horizontal Tab (TAB) character.
- `\v`: Represents the ASCII Vertical Tab (VT) character.

3 Dynamic Type Checking

Expressions evaluate to integers, floats, complex numbers, boolean values, strings or function values. Implementations of Source generate error messages when unexpected values are used as follows.
Only function values can be applied using the syntax:

expression ::= *name* **(** *expressions* **)**

For compound functions, implementations need to check that the number of *expressions* matches the number of parameters.
The following table specifies what arguments Source's operators take and what results they return. Implementations need to check the types of arguments and generate an error message when the types do not match.

operator	argument 1	argument 2	result
`+,-,*`	int	int	int
`+,-,*`	int	float	float
`+,-,*`	int	complex	complex
`+,-,*`	float	int, float	float
`+,-,*`	float	complex	complex
`+,-,*`	complex	int, float, complex	complex
`+`	string	string	string
`/`	int	int, float	float
`/`	int	complex	complex
`/`	float	int, float	float
`/`	float	complex	complex
`/`	complex	int, float, complex	complex
`**`	int	int >= 0	int
`**`	int	int < 0	float
`**`	int	float	float
`**`	int	complex	complex
`**`	float	int, float	float
`**`	float	complex	complex
`**`	complex	int, float, complex	complex
`%`	int	int	int
`%`	int	float	float
`%`	float	float	float
`==`	int,float,complex	int,float,complex	bool
`==`	string	string	bool
`!=`	int,float,complex	int,float,complex	bool
`!=`	string	string	bool
`>`	int,float	int,float	bool
`>`	string	string	bool
`<`	int,float	int,float	bool
`<`	string	string	bool
`>=`	int,float	int,float	bool
`>=`	string	string	bool
`<=`	int,float	int,float	bool
`<=`	string	string	bool
`and`	bool	any	any
`or`	bool	any	any
`not`	bool		bool
`-`	int		int
`-`	float		float
`-`	complex		complex

4 Standard Library

The standard library contains constants and functions that are always available in this language. In py-slang, the standard library functions are not implemented using a conventional split between primitive and predeclared functions. Unlike in Source, where predeclared functions are defined using built-in primitives, all standard library functions in py-slang are written directly in TypeScript and embedded into the runtime of the CSE Machine. These functions are treated as part of the host environment rather than as user-level definitions, and they interact directly with the evaluator's internal control stack and environment. This design simplifies the interpreter architecture and allows for tighter integration with the execution model, enabling better support for visualization, error handling, and platform-specific extensions within the Source Academy learning environment.
The standard library for Python §x is documented in online documentation of Python §x.

Deviations from native Python

We intend the Python §x to be a conservative extension of native Python: Every correct Python §x program should behave *exactly* the same using a Python §x implementation, as it does using a native Python implementation. We assume, of course, that suitable libraries are used by the TypeScript implementation, to account for the predefined names of Python §x. This section lists some exceptions where we think a Python §x implementation should be allowed to deviate from the native Python specification, for the sake of internal consistency and esthetics.

Output Behavior Differences Between py-slang and Standard Python REPL: Python provides an interactive mode, where users can type and immediately evaluate Python expressions line by line. This mode is entered when you simply type python in a terminal without specifying a file. This is commonly referred to as the Python REPL. In the standard Python REPL, any evaluated expression automatically has its result printed to the console, even if the user does not explicitly call `print()`. For example:

```
>>> 1 + 2
3
>>> "hello"
'hello'
```

This is because Python's REPL implicitly displays the return value of each expression, unless it is None.

In contrast, py-slang adopts a more controlled and minimalistic REPL behavior: Only expressions explicitly passed to `print()` produce output. If the expression is evaluated without a print call, no output will appear, even though a value is computed.

For example, in py-slang:

```
print(1 + 2)     # Outputs: 3
```

This design aligns with the pedagogical goals of Source Academy, reinforcing the idea that output should be intentional and explicit, helping students better understand the role of side effects and output operations.

Appendix: Linked List library

Those linked list library functions that are not primitive functions are pre-declared as follows:

```
def pair(x, y):
    """
    PRIMITIVE
    Makes a pair whose head (first component) is x and whose
    tail (second component) is y.

    Parameters:
        x (value): given head
        y (value): given tail

    Returns:
        pair: pair with x as head and y as tail
    """
    pass


def is_pair(x):
    """
    PRIMITIVE
    Returns true if x is a pair and false otherwise.

    Parameters:
        x (value): given value

    Returns:
        boolean: whether x is a pair
    """
    pass


def head(p):
    """
    PRIMITIVE
    Returns head (first component) of given pair p.

    Parameters:
        p (pair): given pair

    Returns:
        value: head of p
    """
    pass


def tail(p):
    """
    PRIMITIVE
    Returns tail (second component) of given pair p.

    Parameters:
        p (pair): given pair

    Returns:
        value: tail of p
    """
    pass
```

```
def is_none(x):
    """
    PRIMITIVE
    Returns true if x is the empty linked list None, and false otherwise.

    Parameters:
        x (value): given value

    Returns:
        boolean: whether x is None
    """
    pass


def is_linked_list(xs):
    """
    PRIMITIVE
    Returns true if xs is a linked list as defined in the textbook, and
    false otherwise.

    Parameters:
        xs (value): given value

    Returns:
        boolean: whether xs is a linked list
    """
    pass


def linked_list(*values):
    """
    PRIMITIVE
    Given n values, returns a linked list of length n. The elements of
    the linked list are the given values in the given order.

    Parameters:
        value (value1, value2, ...values): given values

    Returns:
        linked list: linked list containing all values
    """
    pass


def draw_data(value1, value2, *values):
    """
    PRIMITIVE
    Visualizes the arguments in a separate drawing area in the Source
    Academy using box-and-pointer diagrams.

    Parameters:
        value1 (value1, value2, ...values): given values
    """
    pass


def equal(xs, ys):
    """
    Pure Function: Returns true if both have the same structure (pairs)
```

```
    and identical values at corresponding leaf positions.
    """
    if is_pair(xs):
        return (
            is_pair(ys)
            and equal(head(xs), head(ys))
            and equal(tail(xs), tail(ys))
        )
    elif is_none(xs):
        return is_none(ys)
    elif is_int(xs):
        return is_int(ys) and xs == ys
    elif is_float(xs):
        return is_float(ys) and xs == ys
    elif is_boolean(xs):
        return is_boolean(ys) and xs == ys
    elif is_string(xs):
        return is_string(ys) and xs == ys
    elif is_function(xs):
        return is_function(ys) and xs == ys
    else:
        return xs == ys


def length(xs):
    """
    Returns the length of the linked list xs.
    """
    return _length(xs, 0)


def _length(xs, acc):
    return acc if is_none(xs) else _length(tail(xs), acc + 1)


def map_linked_list(f, xs):
    """
    Returns a linked list that results from linked list xs by element-wise
    application of unary function f.
    """
    return _map_linked_list(f, xs, None)


def _map_linked_list(f, xs, acc):
    return (
        reverse(acc)
        if is_none(xs)
        else _map_linked_list(f, tail(xs), pair(f(head(xs)), acc))
    )


def build_linked_list(fun, n):
    """
    Makes a linked list with n elements by applying the unary function fun
    to the numbers 0 to n - 1.
    """
    return _build_linked_list(n - 1, fun, None)


def _build_linked_list(i, fun, already_built):
```

```
    return (
        already_built
        if i < 0
        else _build_linked_list(i - 1, fun, pair(fun(i), already_built))
    )


def for_each(fun, xs):
    """
    Applies the unary function fun to every element of the linked list xs.
    """
    if is_none(xs):
        return True
    else:
        fun(head(xs))  # Side effect happens here if fun is not pure
        return for_each(fun, tail(xs))


def linked_list_to_string(xs):
    """
    Returns a string that represents linked list xs using the text-based
    box-and-pointer notation.
    """
    return _linked_list_to_string(xs, lambda x: x)


def _linked_list_to_string(xs, cont):
    if is_none(xs):
        return cont("None")
    elif is_pair(xs):
        return _linked_list_to_string(
            head(xs),
            lambda x_str: _linked_list_to_string(
                tail(xs), lambda y_str: cont(f"[{x_str},{y_str}]")
            ),
        )
    else:
        return cont(stringify(xs))


def reverse(xs):
    """
    Returns linked list xs in reverse order.
    """
    return _reverse(xs, None)


def _reverse(original, reversed_acc):
    return (
        reversed_acc
        if is_none(original)
        else _reverse(tail(original), pair(head(original), reversed_acc))
    )


def append(xs, ys):
    """
    Returns a linked list that results from appending the linked list ys
    to the linked list xs.
    """
```

```
    return _append(xs, ys, lambda x: x)


def _append(xs, ys, cont):
    return (
        cont(ys)
        if is_none(xs)
        else _append(tail(xs), ys, lambda zs: cont(pair(head(xs), zs)))
    )


def member(v, xs):
    """
    Returns first postfix sub-linked list whose head is identical to v
    (using ==). Returns None if the element does not occur in the linked
    list.
    """
    if is_none(xs):
        return None
    elif v == head(xs):
        return xs
    else:
        return member(v, tail(xs))


def remove(v, xs):
    """
    Returns a linked list that results from xs by removing the first item
    from xs that is identical (==) to v.
    """
    return _remove(v, xs, None)


def _remove(v, xs, acc):
    if is_none(xs):
        return append(reverse(acc), xs)
    elif v == head(xs):
        return append(reverse(acc), tail(xs))
    else:
        return _remove(v, tail(xs), pair(head(xs), acc))


def remove_all(v, xs):
    """
    Returns a linked list that results from xs by removing all items from
    xs that are identical (==) to v.
    """
    return _remove_all(v, xs, None)


def _remove_all(v, xs, acc):
    if is_none(xs):
        return append(reverse(acc), xs)
    elif v == head(xs):
        return _remove_all(v, tail(xs), acc)
    else:
        return _remove_all(v, tail(xs), pair(head(xs), acc))


def enum_linked_list(start, end):
```

```
    """
    Makes a linked list with elements from start to end (inclusive).
    """
    return _enum_linked_list(start, end, None)


def _enum_linked_list(start, end, acc):
    return (
        reverse(acc)
        if start > end
        else _enum_linked_list(start + 1, end, pair(start, acc))
    )


def list_ref(xs, n):
    """
    Returns the element of linked list xs at position n (0-indexed).
    """
    if n == 0:
        if is_none(xs):
            raise IndexError(
                "linked_list_ref: index out of bounds on None linked list"
            )
        return head(xs)
    else:
        if is_none(xs):
            raise IndexError("linked_list_ref: index out of bounds")
        return list_ref(tail(xs), n - 1)


def accumulate_linked_list(f, initial, xs):
    """
    Applies binary function f to the elements of xs from right-to-left
    order.
    """
    return _accumulate_linked_list(f, initial, xs, lambda x: x)


def _accumulate_linked_list(f, initial, xs, cont):
    if is_none(xs):
        return cont(initial)
    else:
        # Recursive CPS call: Process tail, then apply f with head,
        # then pass to continuation
        return _accumulate_linked_list(
            f,
            initial,
            tail(xs),
            lambda x_accumulated_from_tail: cont(
                f(head(xs), x_accumulated_from_tail)
            ),
        )


def filter_linked_list(pred, xs):
    """
    Returns a linked list that contains only those elements for which the
    one-argument function pred returns true.
    """
    return _filter_linked_list(pred, xs, None)
```

```
def _filter_linked_list(pred, xs, acc):
    if is_none(xs):
        return reverse(acc)
    else:
        if pred(head(xs)):
            return _filter_linked_list(pred, tail(xs), pair(head(xs), acc))
        else:
            return _filter_linked_list(pred, tail(xs), acc)
```